HTML Basics

A Beginner's Guide to Creating Your First Website

This guide explains HTML in simple English. Follow the steps, create your first webpage, and then publish it using GitHub Pages.

What you will learn

• What HTML is and how a webpage is structured

• Common HTML tags

• How to create and open an index.html file

• A complete beginner website example

• How to upload the website to GitHub and publish it with GitHub Pages

Remember: HTML creates the structure of a webpage. CSS makes it look beautiful, and JavaScript adds interactive behaviour.

1. What is HTML?

HTML stands for **HyperText Markup Language**. It tells a web browser what content to show, such as headings, paragraphs, images, and links. HTML is not a programming language; it is a markup language.

2. Basic HTML structure

Every normal HTML page starts with a structure like this:

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<head>
    <title>My First Website</title>
</head>
<body>
    <h1>Hello, World!</h1>
    <p>This is my first webpage.</p>
</body>
</html>
```

• **<!DOCTYPE html>** tells the browser to use modern HTML.

• **<html>** contains the whole webpage.

• **<head>** contains page information, such as the title.

• **<title>** is the text shown on the browser tab.

• **<body>** contains the content people see.

• **<h1>** creates a main heading; ** ** creates a paragraph.

3. Useful HTML tags

Tag	Purpose	Example
<h1>	Main heading	Welcome
	Paragraph	Hello there.
<a>	Clickable link	Visit
<img>	Display an image	<img src="photo.jpg" alt="Photo">
and	Bulleted list	Item
<button>	Button	<button>Click me</button>
 	Line break	First line Second line

Note: Most HTML tags have an opening tag and a closing tag. For example, starts a paragraph and ends it. The image tag is a special case and does not need a closing tag.

4. Build a small website

Copy this example carefully. It makes a simple personal website with a heading, about section, list, and link.

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
    <meta charset="UTF-8">
    <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
    <title>My Personal Website</title>
</head>
<body>
    <h1>Welcome to My Website</h1>
    <p>Hello! I am learning how to build websites.</p>

    <h2>About Me</h2>
    <p>I am a student who enjoys technology and coding.</p>

    <h2>My Interests</h2>
    <ul>
        <li>Learning HTML</li>
        <li>Coding</li>
        <li>Artificial Intelligence</li>
    </ul>

    <p>Thank you for visiting my website!</p>
    <a href="https://github.com/">Visit GitHub</a>
</body>
</html>
```

5. How to open your webpage

1. Open a text editor on your computer, such as Notepad or VS Code.

2. Paste the website code into a new file.

3. Choose Save As and name the file **index.html**. Make sure it does not become index.html.txt.

4. Find the saved file and open it with Chrome or another browser.

5. To make changes, edit the file, save it, and refresh the browser.

> **Phone tip:** You can practise in a mobile code editor that supports HTML, or use GitHub's website editor. A laptop or desktop is usually easier for the first website.

6. Publish the website with GitHub Pages

You can publish a simple HTML website for free using GitHub Pages. First, sign in to your GitHub account.

1. Create a repository: On GitHub, choose the + menu, then New repository.

2. Name it: For a personal website, the repository name can be **your-username.github.io**. For a project website, choose a simple name such as **my-first-website**.

3. Make it public: Select Public, then create the repository.

4. Add your file: Choose Add file → Create new file. Name it **index.html**.

5. Paste the code: Add your HTML code, then choose Commit changes to save it.

6. Enable Pages: Open the repository's Settings → Pages. Under Build and deployment, choose Deploy from a branch, select the main branch and /(root), then Save.

7. Open the site: Wait a few minutes. The Pages section will show the published website link.

> **Important:** GitHub's menus can change. If an option looks different, look for the repository's Settings and then Pages. Never share your password or verification codes.

7. Common mistakes to check

• The filename must be index.html, not index.html.txt.

• Check that every opening tag has the correct closing tag where needed.

• Save your changes before refreshing the browser.

• If GitHub Pages does not show the website immediately, wait a few minutes and check Settings → Pages again.

• HTML controls content structure. Add CSS later to change colours, spacing, and layout.

8. Your practice task

Create a webpage that includes your name or a nickname, one heading, two paragraphs, a list of three interests, and one link. Open it in your browser. After that, publish it using GitHub Pages.

> **Next learning order:** HTML basics → CSS basics → JavaScript basics → GitHub Pages.